

Pierre Trudeau's Legacy: An Analysis of Policy Judgements and Contributions to Separatism

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Civic engagement, especially of youth, is becoming increasingly important to me in recent years as my peers and I come of age. The Canadian identity, and how governments have chosen to define it, has evolved over time, being shaped by various policy decisions. For example, the Canadian state's bilingual nature, requiring the government to use both official languages of French and English in all public services. However, in my daily life in the metro Vancouver area, I seldom hear people who speak French. Additionally, many of my peers who did not spend much of their childhood and teen years in Canadian schooling do not understand the significance of Canada's bilingual nature, particularly because francophone speakers are often concentrated in particular geographical areas. By providing a succinct and focused history on how this facet of Canadian identity came to be, hopefully more people can understand more about the tensions that exist between different entities, in addition to the consideration of francophone culture in policy making. Knowledge of these histories will also help us better inform our civic decision-making and policy judgements.

This paper considers Prime Minister Pierre Trudeau's legacy during his time in office, including his adoption of various culture-defining policies in his quest to define the Canadian identity. Yet, his critics would attach his legacy to the growth of Quebec separatism and Western alienation. As such, this paper will discuss whether Trudeau misconceived the nature of Canada through his policy decisions.

Introduction

Pierre Trudeau, the leader of the Liberal Party, served as the prime minister of Canada for a total of fifteen years, implementing various fundamental policies and laws throughout his leadership that would work towards defining Canada's identity (Janigan et al., 2020; McRoberts, 2019). While these crucial contributions established the foundations of modern day Canada's diverse identity, the accommodating nature of his decisions on public policy played a role in the rise of separatism in Quebec. Currently, many separatists in Quebec hold the belief that the province requires an increased degree of independence and autonomy from Canada in order to properly protect their culture. (Morton et al., 2019). The belief that there is a lack of regard for the preservation of francophone culture within Quebec will only lead to difficulties during projects requiring the cooperation of both the provincial and central government (Berdahl, 2021). Accordingly, this paper will argue that Pierre Trudeau did not misconceive the nature of Canada—the contributions made under his leadership that aided in the development of fundamental Canadian identity and law would have inevitably resulted in discord between various provinces and cultural groups due to their varying historical roots and objectives.

This paper will examine whether Trudeau misconceived Canada's nature through analyzing three of his contributions and their effects on separatist sentiment. Firstly, the *Official Languages Act* (1969) passed by Trudeau's government declared English and French as the official languages of Canada through requiring all federal institutions to provide services in English or French on request (Larendeau, 2019). This paper will examine the perspectives of the French and English-speaking Canadians in response, as well as consider alternative versions of the act that could have been proposed. Secondly, the multiculturalism policy adopted in 1971 intended to increase cultural diversity across the country (Jedwab, 2022). The reasoning behind Trudeau's decision to adopt a multicultural policy as opposed to an alternative will be discussed, in addition to its effects on separatism and the Canadian identity. Thirdly, the patriation of the Canadian Constitution (1982) allowed Canada to fully gain their authority from the British Parliament, who originally controlled all

their laws (Malcolmson et al., 2021) Throughout the process of its patriation, there were situations in which Quebec allegedly received treatment different from that of the other provinces. Lastly, this paper will conclude by discussing the inevitability of disharmony during the development of a historically and culturally diverse country.

Bilingualism

The introduction of the *Official Languages Act* (OLA) in 1969 proclaimed English and French as the official languages of Canada, the goal of which stemmed from Pierre Trudeau's goal of defeating Quebec nationalism through the union and acceptance of both English and French speakers within Canada (Guibernau, 2006; McRoberts, 2019). Seemingly through the act, French-speaking Quebec citizens would not have to worry about getting dominated by the rest of mostly English-speaking Canada. However, whilst French was being more widely implemented into government services across other provinces, the act required the Quebec government to implement more English into the widely French-speaking culture (Gerin-Lajoie, 2019). The mandatory use of English within Quebec only served to further the idea that Quebec—already somewhat of a language minority—was being unfairly dominated by English-speaking decision makers.

In order to justify Trudeau's intended objectives and his judgement, we must consider his decision to implement bilingualism instead of directly choosing a language to officialize. As Canada was predominantly made up of English-speaking groups with roots tracing back to the United Kingdom, presenting English as the official language would have pleased a majority of the citizens (McRoberts, 2019). On the other hand, Quebec, with roots tracing back to France, would have been pleased if the official language were cited as French. The conflict here is obvious—in both cases, one language group would be ostracised. Thus, the best compromise would be to pass an act that approved both languages as official languages, lest the government face extreme backlash from the ignored language group. One remaining alternative would be to declare Canada a multilingual country, with objectives that closely resemble those of the multiculturalism act adopted by the government later on;

for instance, increasing overall lingual diversity across Canada. However, this alternative would leave both the anglophone and francophone populations in an arguably worse position than they would have been had they accepted a bilingual Canada. Quebec has quite a diverse number of minority populations; had their languages been acknowledged as an official one under a multilingual policy, the French language would be in even more danger, as there is no requirement for French to remain a dominantly used language in the province. Still, it is clear why Trudeau chose not to declare Canada multilingual—there would be too much difficulty and ambiguity in terms of what languages should be taught, required, and used in public-sector areas such as education and other government provided services. Though Quebec separatists may have attributed the mandatory use of English in the public sector to the central government—and thus increasing their resentment towards them—Quebec could have been even worse off had Canada not declared French as one of the official languages at all.

Multiculturalism

Issues with Biculturalism

The Multiculturalism Policy was adopted and announced by Trudeau's government in 1971 with the objectives of increasing cultural diversity, as well as quelling the rising nationalist sentiments of French-speakers in Quebec (Jedwab, 2022). The idea of a multiculturalist Canada arose when issues started surrounding the plan of declaring Canada as bicultural came up; the declaration of Canada as bicultural would have mirrored the OLA and further solidified the historical roots of the Canadian identity (Guibernau, 2006). McRoberts further states that a bicultural status would have intended to acknowledge both the cultures of the French and Britain, as well as pay respect to the agreement and cooperation of their colonies that led to the creation of Canada. One issue that arose during this period was the White Paper, which notably proposed to eliminate the important statuses and benefits of the Indigenous people (McRoberts, 2019). If the argument for a bicultural Canada with the cultures of the United Kingdom and France having a place in Canada's

official culture was due to the fact that they were the colonies that cooperated to create Canada, then the First Nations should also fit into this category—however, we can note from this that the government simply did not recognize the Indigenous Peoples as warranting enough respect to have their cultures declared as official, despite their time living on Canadian soil far surpassing that of the new colonies at the time. With the *Official Languages Act*, many anglophone Canadians were unhappy that French was cited for use as an official language in what was a predominantly English-speaking society, just as the francophone Canadians in Quebec were unhappy about the implementation of English (Dufresne & Ruderman, 2018). In the case of biculturalism, in addition to anglophone Canadian and francophone Canadian groups being against the official acknowledgement of the other culture, many other minority cultural groups would have been left out entirely, such as the Indigenous peoples. Thus, the multiculturalism policy was a sufficient alternative to help the federal government get rid of the opposition of these other ethnic groups as they prioritized the further development and integration of official Canadian bilingualism (McRoberts, 2019).

Multiculturalism Effects on Canadian Identity

While the adoption of the multiculturalism policy has contributed to the diversification of Canadian identity, it is this same diversification that leads to the lack of an “official culture” with common values, thus allowing many diverse groups to grow and adopt contradicting and distinct beliefs in comparison to the general political values upheld by the constitution and federal government (Guibernau, 2006). While it is important to acknowledge the historical roots of confederation, the colonies of the United Kingdom and France were not the only or first people that lived on Canadian soil. Multiculturalism has allowed otherwise marginalized minority groups to flourish in comparison to the “melting pot” model of the United States of America (USA), in which cultural differences brought by immigrants seem to melt into a larger American identity (Guibernau, 2006). The acceptance of various cultures as cemented in the Constitution also allows for less oppression against new immigrants

arriving to Canada (Wayland, 1997). Although the celebration of francophone culture has been undermined to an extent due to the multiculturalism policy, many other cultures would have been disregarded entirely had Canada gone ahead with biculturalism (McRoberts, 2019).

Multiculturalism Effects on Separatism

Though one of the objectives of the multiculturalism policy was to alleviate some of the rising separatist sentiment in Quebec, it may have very well contributed to it instead. Despite Quebec largely consisting of a francophone culture, there are areas where the francophone population is outnumbered by other cultural minorities, thus increasing the desperation to recognize a bicultural Canada due to the fear that minorities populations will eventually become the majority as immigration increases (McRoberts, 2019). Similarly to bilingualism, officially recognizing biculturalism would allow for the francophone culture to be more widely spread across Canada, and would decrease the risk of the culture being buried or outnumbered by minorities. However, due to the multiculturalism policy, the many minority groups in Quebec are now legally recognized alongside those who follow the francophone culture, seemingly putting the culture of the french-speaking citizens more at risk, as biculturalism would have declared francophone culture one of the core cultures of Canada, reducing the risk that it would become obsolete. Nevertheless, biculturalism and bilingualism would still present very different effects on the Canadian population if implemented. The language policy would have largely contributed to the use of French in governmental institutions, and has continued to contribute to the public sector of modern Canadian society; for example, in the form of the educational system, where French is taught as a second language in Canada (Bernard, 2010). As Canada continued to urbanize and more governmental institutions were created, the use of French would only become more widespread across the country through its availability in the public sector. In contrast, while the cultures of biculturalism can also be represented in governmental institutions, it is not as simple to incorporate the representation of a culture as opposed to the use of a language on

a widespread scale. For instance, it is much easier to visualize how the French language could be incorporated into the use of governmental services—all services that could be provided in English would also be provided in French. On the other hand, the presentation of a culture is quite difficult; it is not as easy to integrate the more distinct beliefs of a culture into a service the government may be providing. Additionally, it is difficult to believe that minority groups would have completely stopped indulging in various tenets of their respective cultures if a biculturalism policy were declared. Though, it is a different issue if citizens deliberately try to hide aspects of their ethnic cultural celebrations out of fear of being discriminated against. It can also be concluded that the existence of a multiculturalism policy does not prevent any provincial government from passing laws that may conform to the unique beliefs of that region through the existence of Bill 21—a bill that prohibits employees working on behalf of the government from wearing religious symbols with the objective of promoting the neutrality of the state (Kinsinger, 2019). While the multiculturalism policy has contributed to the diversification of Canadian identity, it also makes it harder for a core culture to be defined. However, many ethnic groups are able to freely celebrate their native cultures proudly instead of conforming to a new one.

The Constitution

Initially, motivation to go through with the patriation of the Constitution (1982) was in part in response to the ongoing referendum campaign of the Parti Québécois's government as part of their plan for sovereignty-association—a proposed arrangement that would provide Quebec with further culture and political independence, while still retaining the economic advantages that would come from being a part of Canada's federation (Hudon, 2020; Sheppard, 2020). However, over the course of a night famously dubbed the "Night of the Long Knives", the delegation representing Quebec was not involved during the revisionment of the Constitution and was presented with a completed and revised agreement the morning after, in which all the other provincial governments had already signed. René Lévesque, the Quebec premier, claimed that they were betrayed by the English-speaking

provinces (Sheppard, 2020). Despite their signature merely being a formality now—the Constitution already applies to Quebec in law—this was likely a very important event in the growth of separatism in Quebec. Quebec is still currently the only province that has not signed onto the Constitution, yet the Constitution holds supreme legal power in their province (Malcolmson et al., 2021). Nonetheless, there have since been multiple attempts to obtain Quebec's signature, all of which have unfortunately fallen through (McRoberts, 2021).

Trudeau had the objective and vision of uniting and nationalizing the various regions of Canada during his time in government to create a country more centralized than that of the United States (McRoberts, 2019; Malcolmson et al., 2021). However, due to the many compromises and safety measures that were put in place to garner the agreement and signature of a majority of the provinces—such as section 33, also known as the notwithstanding clause—there are various methods provincial governments can take to pursue their own objectives (Malcolmson et al., 2021). While the implemented Constitution itself does not result in more separatist sentiment—arguably, even favouring Quebec as one of the central provinces in terms of distribution of seats on the House of Commons—it is the process that has had the most effect (Malcolmson et al., 2021). The alleged betrayal of the anglophone provinces in the perspective of the Quebec provincial government and the fact that they are the only province that has yet to sign serves as strong symbolic evidence that supports the argument for Quebec separatism for many of its advocates. However, it is important to note that Quebec would have likely been unsatisfied with any version of the Constitution that the rest of the provinces would have agreed to due to their wish for more unique powers (Sheppard, 2020). In their views, the English-speaking majorities will never prioritise the wishes of the French minority; thus, they can only rely on autonomy and their own power to ensure that their objectives are fulfilled (McRoberts, 2021).

Inevitable Conflict

Although the decisions of Trudeau to implement the versions of the policies he endorsed resulted in lasting conflicts between regions into the modern day, he made

compromises and chose the policies that would lead to the least amount of overall conflict. The colonies of France and the United Kingdom were the ones who collaborated in founding Canada—their distinct differences in culture are what lead to both Canada's respect for diversity as well as its many internal disagreements with respect to identity. The *Official Languages Act* made a compromise between acknowledging both cultures of the founding colonies. The multiculturalism policy allowed for the recognition of many additional minority groups, contributing to the creation of a mindset that is accepting of various cultures among Canadians. Lastly, while the Constitution itself does not directly contribute to separatism, the figurative significance of the exclusion of Quebec during the process of its creation has become a foundation for the arguments of the benefits of separatism. Nonetheless, Trudeau did not misconceive the nature of Canada—he simply made the best decisions that he could regarding identity politics and the policies at the time. The sentiments that resulted and developed onwards after the implementation of Trudeau's various contributions would have been inevitable, and perhaps may have been even worse had his decisions been different, or more in favour of certain regions or cultures. The difficult choices Trudeau made during his time in power have positively encouraged the development and diversification of Canadian identity—ultimately, it is the varied nature of Canada's historical roots that allow for the existence of diverse and unique perspectives and beliefs, even if they lead to political conflict.

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